

*Bradypus pygmaeus*

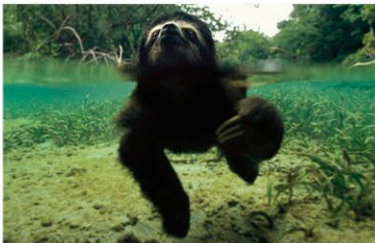
Pygmy three-toed sloth



**Length** 18¼–20½ in (48–53 cm)  
**Tail** 1¼–2¼ in (4.5–6 cm)  
**Weight** 5½–7¼ lb (2.5–3.5 kg)  
**Location** Central America  
**Social unit** Individual  
**Status** Critically endangered



Confined to Isla Escudo de Veraguas off the Caribbean coast of Panama, this diminutive sloth evolved in isolation from its larger mainland ancestors. It is the only sloth that subsists entirely on red mangrove leaves—an adaptation that restricts it to mangrove forest beside the sea. This critically endangered species is threatened by poaching from visiting fishermen and potential tourism development.



*Choloepus didactylus*

Linnaeus' two-toed sloth



**Length** 18–34 in (46–86 cm)  
**Tail** ½–1½ in (1.5–3.5 cm)  
**Weight** 8¼–19 lb (4–8.5 kg)  
**Location** N. South America  
**Social unit** Individual  
**Status** Least concern



Linnaeus' two-toed sloth has 2 hook-clawed toes on each front foot but 3 on each rear one. Its coarse fur is gray-brown, paler on the face, but, like other sloths, it may be tinged green by algae growing on the hairs. It eats a typical sloth's diet of leaves and fruit and, in common with all sloths, is solitary, moves extremely slowly, and descends to the ground only to defecate (about once a week).

*Tamandua tetradactyla*

Southern tamandua



**Length** 21–35 in (53–88 cm)  
**Tail** 16 in (40 cm)  
**Weight** 7¾–19 lb (3.5–8.5 kg)  
**Location** N. and E. South America  
**Social unit** Individual  
**Status** Least concern



Also called the collared anteater, the southern tamandua, has a long, narrow head and sparsely haired, prehensile tail. It climbs well and feeds both in the branches and on the ground, breaking into the nests of ants, termites, and bees. It is active for 8-hour periods, day or night. A single offspring is born after 4–5 months' gestation and rides on the mother.

BLACK VEST

The southern tamandua is pale yellow with a black "vest" over the shoulders, chest, sides, and lower back.



SELF-DEFENSE



When threatened, a southern tamandua backs against a trunk or rock, rears up onto its hind legs, props itself up by its tail, and holds its powerful front legs outstretched. In this position it can slash out at its attacker with the long, sharp claws on its front feet.

*Cyclopes didactylus*

Silky anteater



**Length** 6½–8½ in (16–21 cm)  
**Tail** 6½–9 in (16–23 cm)  
**Weight** 5–10 oz (150–275 g)  
**Location** Central America to N. South America  
**Social unit** Individual  
**Status** Least concern



Solitary and nocturnal, this anteater has long, dense, fine fur, usually smoky gray with a silver sheen and a variable brown stripe on the side of the body. Specialized for arboreal life, it grips strongly with its feet and hooklike claws, supported by its prehensile tail, which is bare on the underside near the tip. It breaks open tree-ant nests and licks out the ants with its long, saliva-coated tongue.

*Myrmecophaga tridactyla*

Giant anteater



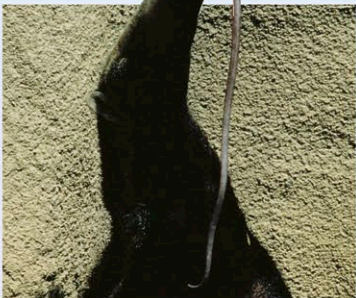
**Length** 3¼–6½ ft (1–2 m)  
**Tail** 25–35 in (64–90 cm)  
**Weight** 49–86 lb (22–39 kg)  
**Location** Central to South America  
**Social unit** Individual  
**Status** Vulnerable



The giant anteater has a long and tubular snout that widens to a small face with tiny ears and eyes. With its massive front legs and smaller rear legs, it walks with an ambling gait, protecting its large front claws from wear by walking on its knuckles. Active day

ANTS'-EYE VIEW

This anteater rips open ant nests and termite mounds with its big-clawed front feet, and then uses its tongue, which can protrude more than 2 ft (60 cm), to take its prey. The tongue is covered with minute, backward-pointing spines and sticky saliva, to which tiny prey adhere. The remaining termites then repair the nest.



and night, this species wanders its home range, which may cover up to 10 square miles (25 square km), depending on the availability of food.

It sleeps in a hollow or in the shelter of bush, its tail draped over its head and body. This species is threatened by hunting and habitat destruction.

NARROW BODY AND BUSHY TAIL

The giant anteater has long, coarse fur on its narrow body. Its coloration is mainly gray with black and white markings. Its brown tail is very bushy.

